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...

**r/LocalLLM** • 5mo ago  
blamestross

...

## HOWTO: Point Openclaw at a local setup

Running OpenClaw on a local llm setup is possible, and even useful, but temper your expectations. I'm running a fairly small model, so maybe you will get better results.

### Your LLM setup

- Everything about openclaw is build on assumptions of having larger models with larger context sizes. Context sizes are a big deal here.
- Because of those limits, expect to use a smaller model, focused on tool use, so you can fit more context onto your gpu
- You need an embedding model too, for memories to work as intended.
- I am running `Qwen3-8B-heretic.Q8_0` on Koboldcpp on a RTX 5070 Ti (16 Gb memory)
- On my cpu, I am running a second instance of Koboldcpp with `qwen3-embedding-0.6b-q4_k_m`

### Server setup

Secure your server. There are a lot of guides, but I won't accept the responsibility for telling you one approach is "the right one" research this.

One big "gotcha" is that OpenClaw uses websockets, which require https if you aren't dialing localhost. Expect to use a reverse proxy or vpn solution for that. I use tailscale and recommend it.

Assumptions:

- Openclaw is running on an isolated machine (VM, container whatever)
- It can talk to your llm instance and you know the URL(s) to let it dial out.
- You have some sort of solution to browse to the the gateway

### Install

Follow the normal directions on [openclaw](#) to start. curl|bash is a horrible thing, but isn't the dumbest thing you are doing today if you are installing openclaw. When setting up `openclaw onboard`, make the following choices:

- I understand this is powerful and inherently risky. Continue?
  - Yes
- Onboarding mode
  - Manual Mode
- What do you want to set up?
- Local gateway (this machine)
- Workspace Directory
  - whatever makes sense for you. don't really matter.
- Model/auth provider
  - Skip for now

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◦ I wish this had "none" as an option. I pick minimax just because it has the least garbage to remove later.

- Default model
  - Enter Model Manually
  - Whatever string your local llm solution uses to provide a model. must be `provider/modelname` it is `koboldcpp/Qwen3-8B-heretic.Q8_0` for me
  - Its going to warn you that doesn't exist. This is as expected.
- Gateway port
  - As you wish. Keep the default if you don't care.
- Gateway bind
  - loopback bind (127.0.0.1)
  - Even if you use tailscale, pick this. Don't use the "built in" tailscale integration it doesn't work right now.
  - This will depend on your setup, I encourage binding to a specific IP over 0.0.0.0
- Gateway auth
  - If this matters, your setup is bad.
  - Getting the gateway setup is a pain, go find another guide for that.
- Tailscale Exposure
  - Off
  - Even if you plan on using tailscale
- Gateway token - see Gateway auth
- Chat Channels
  - As you like, I am using discord until I can get a spare phone number to use signal
- Skills
  - You can't afford skills. Skip. We will even turn the builtin ones off.
- No to everything else
- Skip hooks
- Install and start the gateway
- Attach via browser (Your clawdbot is dead right now, we need to configure it manually)

## Getting Connected

Once you finish onboarding, use whatever method you are going to get https to dail it in the browser. I use tailscale, so `tailscale serve 18789` and I am good to go.

Pair/setup the gateway with your browser. This is a pain, seek help elsewhere.

## Actually use a local llm

Now we need to configure providers so the bot actually does things.

`Config -> Models -> Providers`

- Delete any entries in this section that do exist.
- Create a new provider entry

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- you will see this reset to Select... don't worry, it is because this value is the default. it is OK.
- openclaw is rough around the edges
- Set an api key even if you don't need one `123` is fine
- Base Url will be your openai compatible endpoint. `http://llm-host:5001/api/v1/` for me.
- Add a model entry to the provider
  - Set `id` and `name` to the model name without prefix, `Qwen3-8B-heretic.Q8_0` for me
  - Set `context size`
  - Set `Max tokens` to something nontrivially lower than your context size, this is how much it will generate in a single round

Now finally, you should be able to chat with your bot. The experience won't be great. Half the critical features won't work still, and the prompts are full of garbage we don't need.

## Clean up the cruft

Our todo list:

- Setup `search_memory` tool to work as intended
  - We need that embeddings model!
- Remove all the skills
- Remove useless tools

## Embeddings model

This was a pain. You literally can't use the config UI to do this.

- hit "Raw" in the lower left hand corner of the Config page
- In `agents -> Defaults` add the following json into that stanza

```
"memorySearch": {
  "enabled": true,
  "provider": "openai",
  "remote": {
    "baseUrl": "http://your-embedding-server-url",
    "apiKey": "123",
    "batch": {
      "enabled": false
    }
  },
  "fallback": "none",
  "model": "kcp"
},
```

The `model` field may differ per your provider. For koboldcpp it is `kcp` and the `baseUrl` is `http://your-server:5001/api/extra`

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likely using a smaller model they are just context spam.

Go to the [Skills](#) tab, and hit "disable" on every active skill. Every time you do that, the server will restart itself, taking a few seconds. So you MUST wait to hit the next one for the "Health Ok" to turn green again.

## Prune Tools

You probably want to turn some tools, like [exec](#) but I'm not loading that footgun for you, go follow another tutorial.

You are likely running a smaller model, and many of these tools are just not going to be effective for you.

[Config](#) -> [Tools](#) -> [Deny](#)

Then hit [+ Add](#) a bunch of times and then fill in the blanks. I suggest disabling the following tools:

- canvas
- nodes
- gateway
- agents\_list
- sessions\_list
- sessions\_history
- sessions\_send
- sessions\_spawn
- sessions\_status
- web\_search
- browser

Some of these rely on external services, other are just probably too complex for a model you can self host. This does basically kill most of the bots "self-awareness" but that really just is a self-fork-bomb trap.

## Enjoy

Tell the bot to read `BOOTSTRAP.md` and you are off.

Now, enjoy your sorta functional agent. I have been using mine for tasks that would better be managed by huginn, or another automation tool. I'm a hobbyist, this isn't for profit.

Let me know if you can actually do a useful thing with a self-hosted agent.

↑ 88 ↓ · 💬 103



**mxroute** • 5mo ago

The further it gets from [Opus 4.5](#), the more miserable the bot gets. Found any local LLMs that can actually be convinced to consistently write things to memory so they actually function after compaction or a context reset? Tried [kimi 2.5](#) only to find out that it wrote almost nothing to memory and had to have its instructions rewritten later.

⊖ ↑ 10 ↓



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The model just gets swamped with tokens from the huge and mostly irrelevant prompt and then loses focus.



**KeithHanson** • 5mo ago

[u/blamestross](#) - This is where we can begin hacking if we want some control over this. I am considering forking and modifying here:

<https://github.com/openclaw/openclaw/blob/main/src/agents/system-prompt.ts#L367>

Ideally we just do a big gathering of context variables and interpolate them into a template controlled in the workspace. Seems like a small change? We'd want all this logic I'm sure (I guess... opinions abound about an appropriate way to handle this) to populate the potentially needed variables, but it would be great to have a template for each case (full prompt, minimal, and none), then us local LLM folk could customize it how we need to and still provide most of the original functionality when required.



10 more replies

6 more replies



**hgst-ultrastar** • 5mo ago

I've tried so many models ranging from 30 to 70b and many of them just simply respond with blanks. For example deepseek-r1:30b I just cannot get working.

```
"models": {
  "providers": {
    "ollama": {
      "baseUrl": "http://127.0.0.1:11434/v1",
      "apiKey": "ollama-local",
      "api": "openai-completions",
      "models": [
        {
          "id": "deepseek-r1:32b",
          "name": "deepseek-r1:32b",
          "reasoning": true,
          "input": [
            "text"
          ],
          "cost": {
            "input": 0,
            "output": 0,
            "cacheRead": 0,
            "cacheWrite": 0
          },
          "contextWindow": 131072,
          "maxTokens": 32768
        }
      ]
    }
  }
}
```

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},

2

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**resil\_update\_bad** • 5mo ago

So many weirdly positive comments, and tons of Openclaw posts going around today, it feels suspicious

5

**blamestross** **OP** • 5mo ago

Well, you will find my review isn't horribly positive.

I managed to make it exercise its tools if I held its hand and constantly called out its hallucinations.

Clawbot/molbot/openclaw isn't really a "local agent" until it can run on a local model.

2

1 more reply

**Vegetable\_Address\_43** • 5mo ago

You don't have to disable to skills, instead, you can run the skills.md through another LLM, and then have it make more concise instructions trimming fat. I was able to get an 8b model to use agent browser to pull the news in under a minute doing that.

3

2 more replies

**cbaswag** • 5mo ago

Thank you ! Really wanted to set this up ! My model is also going to be incredibly small but worth looking into, appreciate the hard work!

2

**SnooComics5459** • 5mo ago

Thank you. These instructions are very good. They helped me get my bot up and running. At least I now have a self-hosted bot I can chat with through Telegram, which is pretty neat.

2

**nevetsyad** • 5mo ago

Inspired me to give local LLM another try. Wow, I need a beefier machine after getting this up! lol

Thanks for the info!

2

**tomByrer** • 5mo ago

Seems a few whales bought an M3 Ultra/M4 Max with 96GB+ memory to run this locally.

[Skip to main content](#)[Find anything](#)[Ask](#)[Log In](#)**Toooooool** • 5mo ago

I can't get it working with aphrodite, this whole thing's so far up it's own ass in terms of security that it's giving me a migraine just trying to make the two remotely communicate with one another.

Nice tutorial, but I think I'm just going to wait 'till the devs are done huffing hype fumes for a hopefully more accessible solution. I'm not going to sink another hour into this "trust me bro" slop code with minimal documentation.

2

[2 more replies](#)**zipzapbloop** • 5mo ago

i'm running openclaw on a little proxmox vm with some pinhole tunnels to another workstation with an rtx pro 6000 hosting gpt-oss-120b and text-embedding-nomic-embed-text-v1.5 via lm studio. got the memory system working, hybrid. i'm using bm25 search + vector search and it's pretty damn good so far on the little set of memories it's been building so far.

i communicate with it using telegram. i'm honestly shocked at the performance i'm getting with this agent harness. my head is kinda spinning. this is powerful. i spend a few hours playing with the security model and modifying things myself. slowly adding in capabilities to get familiar with how much power i can give it while maintaining decent sandboxing.

i'm impressed. dangerous, for sure. undeniably fun. havne't even tried it with a proper sota model yet.

2

[5 more replies](#)**blamestross** OP • 5mo ago

Shared over a dozen times and three upvotes. I feel very "saved for later" 🥳

1

[3 more replies](#)**Proof\_Scene\_9281** • 5mo ago

Why would I do this? I'm trying to understand what all this claw madness is. First white claws now this!!?

Seriously tho. Is it like a conversational aid you slap on a local LLM's?

Does it talk? Or all chat text?

1

**blamestross** OP • 5mo ago

I'm not going to drag you into the [clawdbot](#), [moltbot](#), openclaw hype.

Its a fairly general purpose and batteries included [agent framework](#). Makes it easy to let a llm read all your email then do anything it wants.

Mostly people are using it to hype-bait and ruin thier own lives.

5



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[HUGE security risk.](#) "We are gluing together APIs (eg MCP) that have *known vulnerabilities*."

↑ 3 ↓



**JWPapi** • 5mo ago

It's an always-on AI assistant that connects to your messaging apps — Telegram, WhatsApp, Signal. You message it like a contact and it can run commands, manage files, browse the web, remember things across conversations. The appeal is having it available 24/7 without needing a browser tab open. The risk is that if you don't lock it down properly, anyone who can message it can potentially execute commands on your server. I set mine up and wrote about the security side specifically — credential isolation, spending caps, prompt injection awareness: <https://jw.hn/openclaw>

↑ 2 ↓



**ForestDriver** • 5mo ago

I'm running a local gpt 20b model. It works but the latency is horrible. It takes about five minutes for it to respond. I have ollama set to keep the model alive forever. Ollama responds very quickly so I'm not sure why openclaw takes soooo long.

↑ 1 ↓

4 more replies ▾



**Limebird02** • 5mo ago

I've just realized how much I don't know. This stuff is wild. Great guide. I don't understand a lot of the details and knowing that I don't know enough has slowed me down. Safety first though. Sounds to me like some of you may be professional network engineers or infrastructure engineers. Good luck all.

↑ 1 ↓



**SnooGrapes6287** • 5mo ago

Curious if this would run on a radeon card?

Radeon RX 6800/6800 XT / 6900 XT

32Gb DDR5

AMD Ryzen 7 5800X 8-Core Processor × 8

My 2020 build.

↑ 1 ↓



**zedminer** • 2mo ago

Je fais tourner gemma-4-e4b sur un i9, 32Go de ram avec une AMD RX 5500 XT 8 Go ! 5 minute par prompt ! c'est lent mais ca fonctionne .

↑ 2 ↓



**AskRedditOG** • 5mo ago

I've tried so hard to get my openclaw bot to use ollama running on my lan computer but I keep getting an auth error.

I know my bot isn't living, but it feels bad that I can't keep it sustained. It's so depressing

↑ 1 ↓



[Skip to main content](#)[Find anything](#)[Ask](#)[Log In](#)**Inevitable-Orange-43** • 5mo ago

Thanks for the information

[↑](#) 1 [↓](#)**Ijosif** • 5mo ago

Currently I'm trying local as remote API gets expensive fast. (anyone using <https://openrouter.ai/openrouter/free?>) On AMD 7900xtx 24GB VRAM, served by llama.cpp (built 'cmake .. -DGGML\_VULKAN=ON'), currently running

```
./build/bin/llama-server --device Vulkan0 --gpu-layers all --ctx-size 163840 --port 8081 --model  
~/llama.cpp/models/GLM-4.7-Flash-UD-Q4_K_XL.gguf --temp 1.0 --top-p 0.95 --min-p 0.01 --flash-attn  
on --cache-type-k q8_0 --cache-type-v q8_0 --verbose --chat-template chatglm4 --cache-ram 32768 --  
cache-reuse 512 --cache-prompt --batch-size 2048 --ubatch-size 512 --threads-batch 10 --threads 10 --  
mlock --no-mmap --kv-unified --threads-batch 10 > "log_llama-server-glm-4.7-flash-ppid_$$-$(date  
+%Y%m%d_%H%M%S').log" 2>&1 &
```

Without '--chat-template chatglm4' llama.cpp used 'generic template fallback for tool calls', in the log I saw

'Template supports tool calls but does not natively describe tools. The fallback behaviour used may produce bad results, inspect prompt w/ --verbose & consider overriding the template.'

...so I put Claude to fixing that and it got the option. Leaves enough memory to even run an additional tiny model LFM2.5-1.2B-Thinking-UD-Q8\_K\_XL.gguf that I used to run on the CPU. (10-cores 10yrs old Xeon box with 128GB RAM)

[↑](#) 1 [↓](#)

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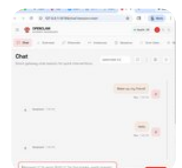
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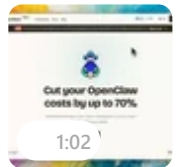
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r/LocalLLM • 3mo ago

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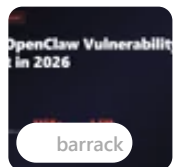
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r/LocalLLaMA • 5mo ago

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